

The “Trap” of School Suspension and Juvenile Arrest: Institutional Interventions to Enhance the Educational Attainment of Sanctioned Students

Education and the Criminal Justice System

The expansion of the criminal justice system and mass incarceration in the late twentieth century coincided with an increasingly punitive approach to juvenile justice and school discipline. The mid-1980s and early 1990s witnessed a historic surge in violent crime, popularly attributed by the media and in political discourse to gang violence among Black urban youth engaged in the trafficking of crack cocaine (Mittleman 2018). This rise in violent offenses provoked a moral panic over the perceived lawlessness and criminality consuming the country. In response, political figures deployed a “tough on crime” rhetoric and implemented policies that drastically expanded criminal surveillance, enhanced enforcement apparatus, and established severe penalties for minor legal infractions. New strategies of police surveillance including “proactive policing,” “order maintenance policing,” and “Broken Windows” policing were devised to closely surveil citizens at low levels of suspicion and severely penalize non-serious crimes and misdemeanors (Mark et al. 2022). While the historical rationale behind the juvenile justice system was rooted in the assumption that youth are less culpable for criminality and more disposed to effective rehabilitation, public anxieties about youth-driven violence impelled states across the country to enact stringent policies regulating the arrest, prosecution, and detention of adolescent offenders (Mittleman 2018). These developments drastically increased rates of juvenile incarceration. By the turn of the twenty-first century, the United States’ imprisoned youth population was the highest in the world and five times greater than that of the next closest country, South Africa (Mittleman 2018). Many of the protections embedded in the juvenile justice system to prevent incriminated children from stigmatization and enduring reputational

disadvantage have also been dismantled. For example, juvenile criminal records, once concealed to safeguard adolescents' futures, are now publicly available in most states (Mittleman 2018).

The reconceptualization of juvenile justice prompted a punitive shift in educational institutions' attitudes toward school discipline. The criminalization of misbehavior in school is the product of three interdependent developments (Mark et al. 2022; Hirschfield 2008). The first is the construction of formalized procedures surrounding school discipline, including zero tolerance policies, that predetermine penalties for student transgressions while restricting teachers' abilities to exercise discretion and adjudicate according to subjective circumstances. These procedures were reinforced by the No Child Left Behind Act, which required that all districts establish formal codes of conduct to serve as blueprints for sanctioning student misbehavior. By guaranteeing the rights of students in "persistently dangerous" schools to transfer to safer institutions, No Child Left Behind also incentivized educational administrations to prove their school's legitimacy by excluding pupils who undermined the school's public image as a safe and secure institution (Kirk and Sampson 2013). The second development in the criminalization of misbehavior is the increased application of exclusionary practices, such as suspensions and expulsions, in response to disciplinary infractions. The third development is the appropriation of criminal justice practices to ensure school security and student compliance with disciplinary codes. This includes the operation of surveillance technologies such as video cameras, metal detectors, and bag checks and the deployment of School Resource Officers (SROs), school-stationed police officers authorized to make arrests and intervene in instances of disciplinary violations. This delegation of arbitrator authority to police has contributed to the formalization of punitive procedures by transferring to law enforcement the task of adjudicating on disciplinary issues that were previously mediated informally by school officials and

counselors. The importation of the “get-tough” approach from the juvenile justice system into school settings and the institutionalization of punitive disciplinary proceedings has significantly increased student susceptibility to suspension and arrest (Wald and Losen 2003). This suspension-arrest relationship reinforces the school-to-prison pipeline, a network of processes through which schools serve as an “auxiliary to the criminal justice system” by funneling adolescents out of the public school system and into the carceral apparatus of the state (Nolan 2011, p. 72). As Black students, students from low socioeconomic backgrounds, and students with disabilities are disproportionately subjected to suspension, these disciplinary procedures exacerbate existing social, racial, and economic inequalities (Mark et al. 2022; Pyne 2019).

A ‘Downward Spiral’: School Sanctions on Educational Outcomes

School suspensions constitute a profound “turning point” in the lives of adolescents, significantly altering their educational trajectories (Kirk and Sampson 2013; Mittleman 2018). Suspended students often demonstrate declines in academic performance following suspension, and they are significantly more likely to drop out of school, engage in subsequent criminal activity, and face imprisonment. Particularly concerning among the educational outcomes affected by suspensions is increased rates of absenteeism. Absenteeism presents a significant threat to academic development, as studies have consistently demonstrated the detrimental causal effects of chronic nonattendance on student achievement and risk of school dropout (Geller and Mark 2022). Reduced school attendance also has serious implications for student health and wellbeing. For many children, particularly the socioeconomically disadvantaged, schools represent “safe havens” or “sanctuaries” where they can eat nourishing meals, utilize health services, and receive meaningful support from attentive and caring adults (Geller and Mark 2022). As suspended students are already a socially vulnerable population prior to exclusion

(Pyne 2019), they may not have access to healthy meals or adult support in the home setting, and suspensions further impede student access to these critical resources. Nonattendance is associated with other negative outcomes on wellbeing, including drug and alcohol use, that may persist into adulthood and increase the likelihood of future substance abuse, marital troubles, lower-level occupations, and unstable career patterns (Stutphen et al. 2010). In addition to severing student access to physical and mental health resources and decreasing the likelihood of future wellbeing, school absence may increase students' risk of exposure to the criminal justice system if adolescents are caught engaging in delinquency outside of school (Geller and Mark 2022). States have recognized the critical importance of school attendance on academic attainment and post-school success. Thirty-six states have made addressing chronic absenteeism a core component of their educational agendas by including it in their accountability plans under the Every Student Succeeds Act (Mark et al. 2022).

Increased absenteeism and school dropout notwithstanding, suspensions also create considerable barriers to educational attainment by institutionally “marking” student offenders in school records (Kohler-Hausmann 2013). As offending students are vulnerable to increasingly severe sanctions should they subsequently misbehave, institutional “marking” amplifies the risk of thwarted academic advancement by drastically raising the stakes of early student misbehavior. This process of escalating consequences is particularly significant given that patterns in punitive discipline often begin early in students' academic careers: a study of a recent national cohort found that 27% of all students, and 39% of Black male students, had already received at least one suspension by age twelve. Such early experience of exclusionary discipline is associated with increased likelihood of arrest in students' teenage years (Mark et al. 2022). Crucially, students are not only “marked” as juvenile delinquents in their particular academic institutions. States

require that disciplinary records follow students not only within but across schools, both public and private (Mittleman 2018). Additionally, college-applying students are often obligated to respond to inquiries regarding prior histories of school disciplining. While as of August 2021 the Common Application removed its question asking whether a student has ever experienced suspension, removal, dismissal, or expulsion from school, many Common Application Member Colleges still require that applicants report disciplinary infractions (Common Application 2023).

School suspensions indelibly stamp sanctioned students, generating major obstacles for continued educational advancement. By deflecting student engagement from school, impeding student capacity for educational success, and compelling students toward closer contact with the criminal justice system, suspensions produce a “downward spiral” or process of cumulative disadvantage that increasingly “mortgages” students’ futures (Mittleman 2018; Mark et al. 2022). Denied the opportunities in adulthood shaped by schooling and bearing the burden of a criminal record, formerly sanctioned students are propelled toward continued criminality. This suggests that school suspensions do not merely penalize juvenile criminality. They contribute to producing it (Mittleman 2018). Despite the demonstrated repercussions of suspension on academic outcomes and life trajectories, however, the practice is pervasive in the public education system. According to the 2016 report from the Digest of Education Statistics, 20% of all public-school students and 48% of Black male students in Grades 6 to 12 received at least one suspension by 2012 (Pyne 2019). Additionally, as minority students and Black male students in particular are significantly more likely to receive suspensions, the persistence of these practices not only helps produce delinquency but reproduce social and racial inequalities.

Policy Alternatives: Student-Centered versus Institutional Interventions

Various policies have been proposed to ameliorate the “downward spiral” produced by school suspensions. Drawing from the nomenclature developed by Mark et al. (2022), these policies will be classified as either student-centered interventions or institutional interventions. The different theories of action informing these policy approaches derive from diverging assessments of the underlying mechanisms driving the disparities in educational attainment among sanctioned students. Student-centric mechanisms are not dependent on changes in institutional behavior, but rather reflect shifts in student attitudes toward and emotional engagement with school as well as effects on student mental and physical health. Proponents of student-centered interventions identify these socio-psychological factors as explanations for the relationship between school suspensions, arrest, and reduced educational advancement. Institutional mechanisms refer to interactions between students and educational and criminal justice institutions, including changes in teacher behavior toward students, escalating exclusionary practices, and criminal case procedures such as arrest, detention, prosecution, and probation that force students to forfeit academic engagement. In contrast to the student-centric framework which assumes that student behavioral and attitudinal changes determine their propensity for educational advancement, this approach emphasizes the ways in which educational institutions systematically expel delinquent students from school settings and examines the incentives schools face to deploy these exclusionary practices. The ensuing sections describe in greater detail the two competing approaches, including supporting evidence from the research literature and proposed policy interventions.

The Student-Centered Approach

The student-centered approach draws extensively on criminological and sociological research to analyze the socio-emotional and socio-psychological factors that obstruct sanctioned

students' educational attainment. Scholars have examined a variety of ways in which student-centric effects can negatively impact academic advancement. Exclusionary discipline and arrest may increase system avoidance behaviors. In an investigation of the impacts of criminal justice contact on institutional engagement, Brayne (2014) finds that individuals who have been stopped by police, arrested, convicted, or imprisoned are less inclined to interact with surveilling institutions that keep formal records of criminal misbehavior, including schools. Other studies have documented increased absenteeism among students in communities that have a strong police presence and are thus more disposed to police encounters on their commutes to school (Burdick-Will et al. 2019). Police contact and arrest can also generate short- and long-term challenges to physical and mental wellbeing, such as chronic stress, that can contribute to increased absences due to illness (Mark et al. 2022; Geller and Mark 2022). Lastly, and most salient in the literature on student-centered mechanisms, the stigmatization and public labeling associated with disciplinary charges may impact student self-conception. Students stigmatized as “deviant” and labeled as “troublemakers” may feel devalued and begin to internalize these identities. This consequently alters academic attitudes, including student thoughts, ideas, and perceptions of the learning environment, as well as behavioral responses (Pyne 2019). When students do not identify with school or perceive their instructors and peers as unsympathetic, uncaring, or hostile, they may emotionally withdraw themselves, leading to adverse socialization and academic disengagement. These coalescing emotional and psychological forces can increase the risk of continued misbehavior, absenteeism, and dropout (Pyne 2019).

Policy responses to student-centric mechanisms involve interventions at the student level. Pyne (2019) argues that schools should prioritize investments in socio-emotional development and trust building, beginning in childhood, to mitigate the need for exclusionary practices. He

encourages schools to adopt compensatory school-based interventions aimed at addressing sanctioned students' negative attitudes and mistrust toward school. Such interventions at the individual level would enhance these students' academic engagement, including their participation in and dedication toward school, and thus ameliorate their academic trajectories. Reviewing the literature on interventions to decrease truancy, Sutphen, Ford, and Flaherty (2010) identify a variety of potential individualized interventions. These include family-based interventions, such as systems of rewards and punishments for attendance and punctuality followed by calls to parents; school reforms, such as the creation of specialized independent academies, after-hours programs for sanctioned students, and detentions for tardies; progressively punitive responses coupled with social services, in which formal school notices of misbehavior are followed by referrals to social services and visits by law enforcement agencies; and community- and relationship-building initiatives.

Though the detrimental effects of student suspension and arrest at the individual level—avoidance behaviors, adverse socialization, mental and physical health challenges—have been well documented, it is empirically unclear that these effects explain declines in sanctioned students' educational outcomes. Pyne (2019) examines how suspension influences students' emotional engagement in school through attitudinal changes. He concludes that suspension might harm students by negatively altering their academic identities and perceptions of school teachers and administrators. While he observes an association between suspension and negative changes in school trust and identification, he also finds that suspensions are not associated with shifts in social belonging, and that consistent with prior studies, suspension does not predict later feelings of school connection. Most important, although these findings corroborate studies demonstrating the negative impacts of exclusionary practices on student self-image and health, it is not clear

that these socio-emotional consequences actually affect educational attainment, and other studies have found minimal evidence to support this hypothesis. Kirk and Sampson (2013) measure the impact of three possible student-centric mechanisms in mediating the effects of arrest on high school dropout, including educational expectations, school attachment, and friend support. They find no evidence that the effects of arrest are mediated by any of the three. The authors thus argue that institutional factors, such as pushout from zero tolerance policies, drive the relationship between arrest and educational outcomes. These findings are further supported by research from Mark et al. (2022). The authors compare attendance rates among arrested and yet-to-be arrested students before and after arrest. Disaggregating observed absences, the authors find little support for the student-centric hypothesis and instead observe that institutional mechanisms, and exclusionary discipline in particular, explain arrested students' disengagement from school.

The Institutional Approach

The institutional approach recognizes that arrest and exclusion are increasingly employed as disciplinary tools that schools are incentivized to utilize. The principal justification for exclusionary discipline is the exigency to preserve school security and control, especially as deadly mass school shootings at Columbine High School in 1999, Sandy Hook Elementary School in 2012, and Stoneman Douglas High School in 2018 have intensified concerns over school safety from gun violence (Gottfredson et al. 2020). If schools believe that misbehaving students decrease the test scores of well-behaved students in the same classroom, they may also be incentivized to implement exclusionary practices in order to remove substandard students and enhance the selectivity of their student body (Heilig and Darling-Hammond 2008; Hwang and Domina 2021). Such incentives are reinforced by a pervasive culture of test-based accountability

in which performance on high-stakes assessments is used to evaluate school quality. In addition to these institutional incentives to exclude students, suspended and arrested students' educational trajectories may be hampered by incapacitation due to involvement with the criminal justice system. Formal legal procedures requiring time spent in court, meetings with social workers and probation officers, and juvenile detention centers may require that students miss school (Mark et al. 2022; Geller and Mark 2022). In an ethnographic study of a heavily policed Bronx high school, Nolan (2011) observed that court summons issued by police officers to misbehaving students constituted a key component of school administrators' strategies to maintain order in school settings. The loss of learning time resulting from such incapacitation could exacerbate existing academic issues, causing students to fall behind and disengage from schoolwork.

The most consequential institutional mechanism is increased school surveillance of penalized students. Regardless of student behavioral change, this inflates the likelihood of subsequent punishment by increasing student exposure to exclusionary discipline (Mark et al. 2022). This phenomenon has been documented in numerous studies, and it provides a potent challenge to the student-centric approach by demonstrating how the discipline apparatus formalizes a process of cumulative criminalization that unduly disadvantages suspended and arrested students. In accordance with Kirk and Sampson (2013) and Mark et al. (2022), Mittleman (2018) affirms that post-suspension behavioral issues do not explain the association between suspension and later arrest. Instead, what distinguishes suspended students from their non-suspended peers is their increased risk for repeated school sanctions. Examining the relationship between childhood suspension and risk for juvenile arrest, Mittleman found that suspended students were more than twice as likely to be arrested than non-suspended students with the same observable risk for suspension. He also observed that repeated school removal

accounted for 52% of the association between childhood suspension and juvenile arrest.

Mittleman thus concludes that the single factor that best explains suspended students' arrest rates is unrelated to behavior: it is their elevated risk for repeated school sanction.

Policy Recommendations

The limited empirical support for the student-centric hypothesis and compelling evidence on institutional obstruction stipulates the need for institutionally focused policy interventions. As research identifies sanctioned students' increased risk for repeated school punishment as the most significant factor driving the suspension-arrest relationship, efforts to enhance these students' educational attainment should work toward eliminating exclusionary discipline in favor of inclusionary practices. Reassessing the role of School Resource Officers (SROs) is critical to reconceptualizing and restructuring school discipline, as SROs are often the principal enforcers of exclusionary practices. In the short-term, school administrators should clearly define and restrict the roles and responsibilities of SROs in school settings. In the long-term, policymakers should remove SROs from schools and invest the funds formerly used for school police forces in support services and training for inclusionary discipline reforms.

Short-Term: Define and Restrict the Roles of SROs

Police presence on school grounds has increased dramatically in recent decades. In 1976, only 1% of American schools had stationed law enforcement officers. By 2016, 48% of all schools and 65% of secondary schools had SROs present at least once per week (Gottfredson et al. 2020). School-stationed police forces are particularly prevalent in large public high schools. 84% of secondary schools with enrollments above 1,000 reported regular SRO presence (Gottfredson et al. 2020). Despite the pervasiveness of police presence at schools, many districts do not have formal agreements about the responsibilities of SROs. This has blurred the

boundaries between the role of SROs and school administrators in conflict mediation, licensing SROs to intervene in and severely penalize noncriminal behavior and minor offenses.

Establishing an agreement that clearly defines the scope of SRO authority and that is understood and accepted by SROs, administrators, teachers, parents, and students would mitigate officers' role in facilitating exclusionary discipline. A case study on a county that implemented systematic changes and devised a set of rules governing SRO conduct found significant declines in court and felony referral rates and an 80% increase in graduation rate (King and Schindler 2021).

Long-Term: Remove SROs from Schools

Research consistently demonstrates that police presence in schools increases records of school crime and exclusionary responses to disciplinary infractions without significantly reducing school crime (Geller and Mark 2022). Schools with SROs have higher reporting of crime, higher probabilities of harsher penalties for students, higher rates of weapon- and drug-related crimes, and more reporting of non-serious violent crimes compared to schools without SROs (King and Schindler 2021). Thus, SROs have not made schools and children safer. Rather, in advancing exclusionary discipline practices and reinforcing the suspension-arrest relationship, they have helped produce criminality. Concerns related to the removal of SROs may be twofold. The first concern regards the potential for increased rates of crime in school settings. The second considers the effects that misbehaving or formerly sanctioned students may have on the academic performance of other well-behaving students.

Will schools become less safe? It is clear from the research that school records of crime do not decrease, but instead increase, with SRO employment. However, SRO proponents may argue that the elevation of crime in schools with SROs is merely a temporary reflection of spikes in recorded disciplinary incidents as police respond to infractions and responsible students are

removed from school. This “crack down” on misbehavior may deter misconduct among remaining students such that the initial increase in reported incidents declines as troublesome students are excluded from schools (Geller and Mark 2022). This explanation is not supported by the data. Examining the effects of increased SRO staffing levels at 11- and 20-months post-intervention, Geller and Mark (2022) observe that recorded crimes and exclusionary responses persist for at least 20 months, suggesting that SRO presence does not make schools safer in the long term. Additionally, rates of juvenile arrest and school-based victimization are falling, reflective of national declines in crime rates (King and Schindler 2021). According to a 2017 report from the National Center for Education Statistics, victimization, theft, and violent crime are at a multi-decade low (King and Schindler 2021). In 2019, only 8% of students reported having a physical fight on school grounds, a significant decline since the 1990s (Lecture 22), and in the 2015-2016 academic year, homicides at school accounted for only 1.2% of total youth homicides (King and Schindler 2021). Both students and parents demonstrate declining concerns about school safety (Lecture 22). While the number of deadly school shootings has significantly increased in recent years, no empirical evidence supports the claim that continued deployment of SROs will prevent the occurrence of mass shootings (Gottfredson et al. 2020), and SROs’ failure to intervene in recent mass shootings in Parkland, Florida, and Uvalde, Texas, challenge the assumption that law enforcement presence protects schools from shootings. Thus, removing SROs will not make schools less safe. Schools experiencing extremely high levels of violence may benefit from continued SRO presence. However, most schools can maintain access to beneficial resources provided by police officers by having an SRO affiliated with the school and prepared to respond in crisis situations, but not regularly stationed (Geller and Mark 2022). While declining concerns about school safety suggest that parental resistance to SRO removal

may be minimal, and prior tragedies have proven that police presence is not a foolproof protection against school shootings, policymakers should take care to address parents' fears of and the real increased rates of school shootings by coupling the removal of SROs with a comprehensive and evidence-based strategy to safeguard schools from mass gun violence.

Will student misbehavior negatively affect academic performance? Stakeholders may be concerned that students with behavioral problems distract teachers, reduce instructional time, and negatively impact academic achievement by creating unstable learning environments. They may believe that SRO presence improves the academic performance of non-sanctioned students by maintaining an environment that is conducive to learning. These assumptions are not supported by the research. Studies investigating the effects of increased SROs on academic outcomes have observed subsequent reductions in graduation and college enrollment rates (Weisburst 2019). Additionally, fewer teachers are reporting that student misbehavior interferes with their teaching (Lecture 22). Such findings challenge the contention that SRO presence is needed to maintain a school environment that is conducive to learning.

Long-Term: Redirect SRO Funding

The greatest challenge to public education that schools identify is not students' lack of discipline. It is schools' lack of financial support (Lecture 22). SROs represent significant financial burdens for schools—the average SRO salary can cost a locality \$70,000 (King and Schindler 2021)—and these costs may detract from investments in other school support services. For example, a report from the American Civil Liberties Union determined that one in four students attends a school with an SRO but no counselor, nurse, social worker, or school psychologist (American Civil Liberties Union 2019). By removing SROs, schools can redirect police funding toward investments in inclusionary, rather than exclusionary, discipline. This may

include investments in school personnel trained to handle student misbehavior as well as social support and counseling services. Funding toward teacher and administrator training in restorative justice practices would also represent a significant step toward inclusive responses to misbehavior. Restorative justice programs have demonstrated promising declines in rates of suspensions and racial disparities in school discipline, and they have been associated with improved school climates (González 2012).

Conclusion

Police presence on school grounds increases school crime and exclusionary discipline, contributing to a cycle of suspension and arrest and precipitating a “downward spiral” that derails students’ educational attainment and life trajectories. While the National Association of School Resource Officers (NASRO) asserts that the principal goal of SROs is to make schools and children safer, research reveals that SROs do not make schools safer. School police officers help produce criminality by deploying punitive responses to delinquent behavior that should instead be managed by school administrators. As Black students, students with disabilities, and economically disadvantaged students are disproportionately subjected to exclusionary discipline, law enforcement presence in schools also exacerbates existing social, racial, and economic inequalities. Removing SROs from school settings would interrupt a critical mechanism of the school-to-prison pipeline and allow schools to redirect police funds toward resources, reforms, and programs that aim to prevent and respond to misbehavior through inclusionary practices.

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